



ORIGINAL ARTICLE

Integrating Participatory Action Research in the Anthropology Classroom Through Black Oral History: Process, Outcomes, and the Future

Jeffrey Shenton¹ | Michael Hughes² | Santiago Lebron¹ | Cindy Zamarripa¹

¹Centre College, Danville, Kentucky, USA | ²Danville-Boyle County African American Historical Society, Danville, Kentucky, USA

Correspondence: Jeffrey Shenton (jeffrey.shenton@centre.edu)

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ABSTRACT

We discuss a multi-year partnership between Centre College and the Danville-Boyle County African American Historical Society (DBCAAHS) that focused on training students to execute and archive semi-structured oral history interviews with members of the local Black community who experienced Danville's urban renewal and school integration period. The project culminated with a large-scale public history exhibition and an archival website. Pedagogically, the project successfully made visible local manifestations of structural racism, both to Centre students and the community. We argue that this project demonstrates a successful fusion of Participatory Action Research (PAR) with ethnographic methods from cultural anthropology. In carrying out this project within several college courses, we further show that tying principles of PAR to ethnographic methods reconciles some of the historical tensions that applied anthropology has had with the community-engaged learning model in higher education. We continue implementing PAR in this article by analyzing debrief interviews with both research participants and students, whose inferences and feedback demonstrate the current outcomes and inform the future shape of the project.

1 | Introduction

We describe the content, process, and outcomes for an ongoing, multi-year project founded on principles of “Participatory Action Research” (PAR), which partnered the first author, a white faculty member of cultural anthropology at Centre College, a predominantly and historically white institution of higher education (PWI) and small liberal arts college (SLAC) in Danville, Kentucky, with a local Black historical foundation, the Danville-Boyle County African American Historical Society (DBCAAHS). Centre College's research contribution to this partnership has been to capacitate Centre undergraduate students to plan, execute, transcribe, and archive semi-structured oral history interviews with local members of the Black community who lived through

Danville's urban renewal and school integration period in the 1960s and 1970s.

This partnership began when the first author and members of DBCAAHS determined that collecting local Black oral histories was an unmet and time-limited need.¹ DBCAAHS members defined this need as the imperative to provide a historical corrective to the prevailing white narrative that local federally funded urban renewal projects and mandated school desegregation served only as “public goods.” Historically, this narrative has gone hand-in-hand with a concomitant suppression of the local Black perspective on the negative consequences of these infrastructure projects on local Black neighborhoods, entrepreneurship, and lived sense of community. As a strategic form of language-

narrative-, and memory-focused PAR, this project also fits into recent calls to amplify the public and applied aspects of linguistic anthropology via so-called “engaged linguistic anthropology” (Avineri and Ahlers 2023).

Our oral history and local Black history education project provides one productive means by which classic cultural anthropological research methods can be translated into a PAR framework successfully within the bureaucratic constraints of the college institution’s term schedule. We argue that capacitating undergraduate students with ethnographic methods resulted in the project successfully fulfilling the aspirational mandates of PAR, which include “the co-generation of the research agenda, methods, research processes, analysis of outcomes, and implementation of research between professional social researchers and members of the affected communities” (Elvemo et al. 1997, 2). By marrying the undergraduate teaching of ethnographic methods to a PAR framework, we achieved both our pedagogical and community-focused aims. For undergraduates, another central aim was to raise awareness of structural racism² from a grounded and empirical perspective. For members of the local Black community, the aim was to provide a previously unavailable avenue to furnish a public corrective to the “official” (white) narrative of local urban renewal and school desegregation projects. Both students and community members were also able to locate the local case within a larger spatio-temporal framework reflecting ongoing processes and legacies of structural racism in the United States.

The success of these pedagogical and community-focused outcomes is empirically attested below. These data represent a further aspect of PAR and its relationship to anthropological methods that we explore in this article: that PAR demands continual, iterative feedback from all stakeholders involved in, responsible for, and affected by the research project (Elvemo et al. 1997). We do this here by reporting on debrief interviews both with local community members who provided their oral history to the project and from Centre students who interacted with or generated artifacts from the project. The results indicate broadly that both students and community members perceived our research project to be an enduring “public good” for the local community.

1.1 | Teaching Anthropological Methods and Doing Participatory Action

Our project was conceived from the beginning as “course-based PAR” (e.g., Dancis et al. 2023; Elvemo et al. 1997; Ritterbusch 2019), in that our partnership was intended to be a longitudinal triangulation between DBCAHHS, Centre College students, and Centre College’s resources and infrastructure, with the first author coordinating this complex set of relationships and providing pedagogical content to undergraduate students alongside DBCAHHS. In this framing, Centre College would furnish the resources (person power, training, hardware, software, and cloud storage) necessary to carry out and archive a large-scale oral history project. The leadership of DBCAHHS was interested in using these resources to fulfill its own pedagogical mission, which is to spread awareness of local Black history to students and the regional community through direct instruction and the provision of wide, public access to historical photographs, physical artifacts

related to local Black history, and archived conversations with older African American residents of Danville and Boyle County.

From a skills-based perspective, focusing on ethnographic methods allowed us to marshal PAR principles to deliver on some of the concrete undergraduate student “outcomes” that serve as currency in today’s higher education setting, in particular relational and inductive reasoning skills that complement and counterbalance the skills prioritized in the STEM disciplines (e.g., Tett 2021). These outcomes include those outlined in Wright (2015): (1) engagement in a *pedagogy of praxis*, “in which young people develop their critical analysis about the nature of the problems they aim to address and then engage in leading a research-based action plan to address them,” (2) engagement of their *sociopolitical analysis development* skills, in which students become able to connect “personal, micro-level experiences of sociopolitical inequities into larger, macro-level sociopolitical forces,” and (3) engagement with *relational leadership*, in which students “shar[e] ideas through a collaborative process to make project decisions” (170, italics in original). In addition, students participating in this project also gained concrete, reproducible, and “marketable” skills in ethnographic semi-structured interviewing, transcribing, archiving, and audio/video editing.

This suite of outcomes applies directly to pragmatic aspects of teaching cultural anthropology through praxis and overcoming outdated understandings of anthropological fieldwork as being the province of the “lone researcher archetype” (Stein et al. 2016, 164). Traditional anthropological teaching tends to relegate the student experience to learning *about* research findings that are perceived to be the result of “hard slogging without peer or emotional support in isolated field sites” (164). In line with Stein et al. (2016), we argue that “collaborative, team-centered pedagogy” in ethnography is key for students and their institutions to understand anthropology as a skill-centered discipline with applications across a broad range of career paths.

A historical ambivalence to community-engaged learning in anthropology (Barone and Ritter 2010; Keene and Colligan 2004) is ironic, considering the foundational roles of fieldwork, cultural relativism, and participant observation in cultural anthropological research. As scholars have pointed out (Campbell and Lassiter 2010; Copeland et al. 2016; Madeiros and Guzmán 2016; Polin and Keene 2010), training students in ethnographic methods such as participant observation and interviewing techniques can imbue traditional community-engaged learning with scope and impact for both community members and students and undergird the imperative that such projects be sustainable, reflexive, and attuned to evolving community needs and desires.

In thinking about the relationship between anthropology as discipline and the practice of engaged learning, Rodríguez-Mejía (2021, 18–19) provides a table comparing the characteristics of community-engaged learning courses, on the one hand, and applied anthropology projects in the higher-education classroom, on the other. Rodríguez-Mejía makes the point that community-engaged learning and applied anthropology projects have overlapping but, importantly, separate practices, agendas, and outcomes. We provide a modified version of this table (see Table 1, modified from Rodríguez-Mejía 2021) to emphasize that projects such as the one described here, which imbue

TABLE 1 | Comparison of community-engaged learning, applied anthropology, and PAR-informed ethnographic methods approaches to teaching and learning (table modified from Rodríguez-Mejía 2021).

	Community-engaged learning	Applied anthropology	PAR-informed ethnographic methods (e.g., the “We Were Here” Project)
Engages students in different kinds of community settings	X	X	X
Encourages students to reflect on their encounters with other community members	X	X	X
Encourages students to reflect on their encounters with other community members	X	X	X
Sets specific outcomes for students (e.g. reports, presentations, publications)	X	X	X
Largely focused on forming long-term partnerships between universities and communities	X		X
Has strong focus on civic engagement	X		X
Largely focused on providing ethnographic research training		X	X
Research and service have equal weight		X	X
Has strong focus on teaching problem solving skills and cultural differences		X	X
Is spearheaded by individual professors for specific research projects		X	X
Is spearheaded by specific campus units (e.g., offices for engaged learning)	X		

community-engaged learning projects with PAR-informed ethnographic methods, are one way of bridging the pedagogical gap in anthropological teaching between community engagement and capacitating students with disciplinary methods.

1.2 | PAR and the Anthropology Classroom: Challenges and Possibilities

In reflections on course-based undergraduate research initiatives that push back on unilateral, outcome-oriented, neoliberal modes of knowledge production that reify the epistemological status quo (Dancis et al. 2023; Kindon and Elwood 2009), a recurring theme is the difficulty of fitting the spatial, temporal, and content-based expectations of the college course (course credit, grading and assessment, skill transfer) to methods that are participatory and liberatory (Lykes et al. 2018). Much of this discussion falls under the umbrella of PAR, which has developed over the past century as a transdisciplinary alternative to “status quo” knowledge production and research (Fine and Torre 2021; Mirra et al. 2015; Torre et al. 2012). PAR, at its heart, marries existing modes of critical theory (feminist, critical race, queer, disability, neo-Marxist, Indigenous, and poststructural) to a praxis of democratic participation (Torre et al. 2012). As glossed by Dancis et al., PAR is “by definition political because it de-centers the professionalized university-based knower, centers participant-researchers

as experts, focuses on changing inequitable social/institutional structures, and reconfigures ideas about whom research is for and to whom the university-based professionalized researcher is accountable” (2023, 2; see also Fine and Torre 2021).

Within higher education, promoting alternative epistemologies through engaged and participatory methodologies is especially attractive within cultural anthropology, which is faced with applying its recent aspiration to participate in public-facing/liberatory action (Borofsky and De Lauri 2019) to its historical identity as a discipline founded within the colonial imagination (Baba 2009; Keene and Colligan 2004). Taken in their traditional guises, even cultural anthropology’s hallmark methods, ethnography and participant-observation, are susceptible to unilateral and “top-down” approaches that ignore community agency and thereby shut down possibilities for collaboration and co-creation of knowledge, for which PAR is one potential corrective (Sosnowski et al. 2022).

“Course-based PAR,” in which PAR research is conducted within the confines of a credit-bearing university course, presents significant challenges to instructors, students, and community partners alike, which are obvious and have been long recognized (e.g., Elvemo et al. 1997). Indeed, for Elvemo and colleagues, who write about their attempts to apply PAR to the anthropology classroom, teaching PAR reflects “significant contradictions,”

which include the “impersonal,” “routinely hierarchical and bureaucratic” nature of the “academic setting” in which the “authority of the faculty member in charge is nearly absolute” (1997, 1). Dancis et al. (2023) point to more pragmatic structural barriers in the classroom setting. These include the time-limited nature of the term structure (e.g., quarter, semester, short term, etc.), which forces instructors to make consequential choices for PAR projects: either time-limited one-off projects that sometimes render engagement and collaboration superficial, or structuring projects in a longitudinal fashion, which may limit the visibility and scope of impact for individual enrolled students.

Another structural issue these authors emphasize in course-based PAR they term “problem definition” (Dancis et al. 2023, 4), or the question of who defines the problem to be investigated. Ideally, PAR is focused on centering the democratic process in terms of problem, research, and community needs. Thus, students, faculty, and community partners would collaborate equally to define needs and to execute research. However, this has significant consequences for time and scheduling and can also have consequences for student recruitment, since students often choose courses topically. On the other hand, if the instructor defines the problem and the nature of the research beforehand, while the course throughline and student motivation may be higher, this comes at the expense of full engagement in the democratic process prioritized in “pure” PAR approaches.

Ritterbusch (2019) highlights a more foundational threat to course-based PAR approaches. While the commitments of many instructors of PAR-based courses may be in line with the radical public and applied intentions of PAR projects, employing them within a classroom context can make them susceptible to what Ritterbusch calls “lite pedagogies” (2019, 1297), which reduce the complexities of forming and sustaining community-researcher relationships in the name of social justice to a “toolkit” or paint-by-numbers approach (2019, 1303). Ritterbusch attributes the pressure to sacrifice process and engagement for outcomes to constraints imposed by the bureaucratic structure of the university, including the timeframe of the term schedule and administrative demands for student safety and to avoid legal liability.

In this project, we carried out a student-led course-based oral history project, employed PAR principles in partnership with the local community, and brought about productive skills-based student outcomes by capacitating undergraduate students in classic methods from cultural anthropology. Beyond augmenting student skill sets and marrying ethnographic practice to PAR principles, this synthesis of methods and outcomes speaks directly to recent calls to teach social change through student-led action (Myers-Lipton 2023). To do so, we placed students into direct conversation with local members of the Black community who could describe the consequences of local urban renewal and school desegregation policies. Students then became the stewards of these narratives’ legacies, both in terms of eliciting and interpreting them and also in the practical sense of working with the Grace Doherty Library at Centre College to create a publicly accessible archive and large-scale public exhibition (see below). We thus put this project in line with recent work showing that skills-based ethnographic practice in the undergraduate classroom is consonant with teaching social justice in a robust and durable way (e.g., Kinyon and Cerón 2023).

1.3 | Urban Renewal in Danville³

The “urban renewal” period in the United States began with the passing of the Housing Act of 1949 and was further entrenched with the Housing Act of 1954. Both acts allowed local housing authorities to identify “slums and blighted areas” for “clearance” and then “redevelopment” using federal funds (Biles 2011). Between 1949 and the mid-1970s, when funding for urban renewal projects dried up, somewhere between 2000 and 3000 such projects were carried out in more than 1000 municipalities in the United States, to the tune of \$13 billion in federal dollars given out to local municipalities (Fullilove, n.d., Fullilove 2016; University of Richmond Digital Scholarship Lab, n.d.). Comprehensive demographic statistics on those displaced by these projects were only kept until 1966, but even with these truncated statistics, the scale of the program was demonstrably skewed in terms of race. More than six hundred municipalities in the United States displaced families, and of the minimum one-third of a million families displaced, the large majority of these families were of color. In many locations, including large cities like Philadelphia, more than two-thirds of displaced families were of color (University of Richmond Digital Scholarship Lab, n.d.).

In Danville, Kentucky, the urban renewal period was a microcosm of these larger trends. According to local historian Mike Denis, six areas of the city in total were affected by urban renewal in a process that stretched from 1960 until at least the mid-1980s (personal communication).

The first of these projects was directly motivated by Centre College’s interests in expansion and “beautification.” The college had integrated its campus with the Kentucky College for Women in 1962 and constructed three new dormitories for women on the north side of Main Street (Weston 2019). As part of the planning for campus gender integration, Centre College proposed annexing the area along North Seventh Street, which ran perpendicular to Main Street, and Rowe Street, which ran parallel to Main Street on its north side. Both areas were inhabited exclusively by Black families, most of whom were renters. The federal government agreed to match Centre’s commitment to spend \$180,000 on the project at two-to-one (Bailey Heard at Breakfast Honoring Centre, 1961); this eventually became a grant of \$519,600 by the time the project was approved in July of 1964 (Urban Renewal Project Is Given Green Light, 1964). After the area was cleared of housing (not completed until 1969; Urban Renewal Buys May Start In Sept., 1969), this area became a soccer field and recreation area. In the late 2010s, Centre College built another dorm in this area.

The second urban renewal project, which overlapped substantially in time with the Seventh Street project, removed a Black entrepreneurial district that stretched along the block of South Second Street from Main Street. This area had developed over the course of the 20th century as a hub for Black people and families from Danville and the surrounding Boyle County area and contained, over the years, a succession of restaurants, barber shops, cab companies, and an iconic Black Masonic Lodge, the “Doric Lodge.” The Second Street urban renewal project was first “endorsed” by Danville’s Chamber of Commerce in late 1965 (Retail Merchants ‘Endorse in Principle’ 2nd Street Urban Renewal Development, 1965), but it was not until 1970 that the full \$1.46 million of combined loan and grant money was

awarded for the project by the Department of Housing and Urban Development (Urban Renewal Plan On 2nd Street May Start Immediately, 1970). Demolition began in December of 1970 (Clearing Urban Renewal Land, 1970) and continued through 1972 (Towles 1972), but there were delays because some property owners refused to sell, forcing the Danville Urban Renewal Agency to file multiple rounds of condemnation suits to acquire all of the properties (Suits Are Filed For Property, 1971; Take Action To Acquire 4 Properties, 1972). The last of these properties was not acquired until the middle of 1974 (Last Tract Purchased By Urban Renewal, 1974). Because this project removed Black-owned businesses and Black public space, the “Second Street Project” has become the emotional centerpiece of the urban renewal period for the remaining Black community, representing what the community lost during that time.

In all, the net effect of these projects, as we have heard from person after person in oral history interviews, was the successful dissolution of the Black community in the Danville area. While some people were successfully re-housed in town, for example to the housing project called Batewood Homes further south on Second Street, many people simply left Boyle County altogether (Michael Hughes and Charles Grey, personal communication). In at least one documented instance, the initial promise of rehousing and home ownership was thwarted when members of the Urban Renewal Agency reneged on the price of the house to be built, telling the buyer that he would have to take out a second mortgage to purchase the new home (James Hunn, personal communication).

1.4 | Centre/DBCAAHS Partnership⁴

DBCAAHS was founded in 2013, and its institutional mission is to be “committed to the collection, preservation, accessibility, promotion, and communication of the history of the Danville-Boyle County African American community” (Danville Boyle County African American Historical Society: About Us, n.d.). The motivation for founding DBCAAHS came from Mr. Michael Hughes, a nearly lifelong resident of Danville who has served as DBCAAHS president since its founding. The lack of contemporary local knowledge or of any systematic accounting of either the urban renewal period or the Black experience in Boyle County more generally was a key reason to found DBCAAHS (Michael Hughes and Michael Denis, personal communication). Since 2013, Mr. Hughes has collected thousands of photographs from local Black families that he regularly colorizes and posts on Facebook.

The first author and Mr. Hughes initiated the Centre-DBCAAHS partnership in 2019. The original partnership was modest in scale: students enrolled in the first author’s Introduction to Cultural Anthropology course visited the site of the Second Street urban renewal project and heard Mr. Hughes recount the outlines of this history in the DBCAAHS space on North Second Street. These students began work on what would become the timeline of the “official record” of Danville’s urban renewal period as presented in the *Danville Advocate-Messenger*.⁵ Students in this course continue to interface with DBCAAHS in this way to this day. However, it also sparked a conversation about ways to increase the scale of Centre student involvement in local Black history, which led to the idea of capacitating students to conduct oral history

interviews with members of the local Black community who had been affected by urban renewal. DBCAAHS had some recorded interviews but lacked the time, hardware, and person power to interview people systematically. The eventual outcome of this effort was the creation of the course “Lived Histories,” which focuses thematically on situating urban renewal, both locally and nationally, in the *longue durée* of African American history in the United States.

The “Lived Histories” course reflects recent calls for an interdisciplinary focus on community-based research specifically to raise awareness of, and seeking to eliminate, structural inequities based on race (e.g., Goings et al. 2023). The claim that such intentionally antiracist research also has pedagogical applications is, further, in line with liberatory pedagogical practice going back to the work of Paolo Freire (2005). Famously, Freire called for a “pedagogy of praxis” that would subvert static and passive “banking” modes of education (in which students are told to memorize decontextualized, authoritative information in a classroom) and thereby more thoroughly integrate contextualized knowledge as “co-investigators in dialogue with the teacher” (2005 [1970], 81). Such experiential practice is foundational to contemporary views of pedagogy in the social justice classroom that seek to motivate students to confront the discomfort and cognitive dissonance upon “hear[ing] perspectives and learn[ing] information that contradict what they had previously believed or might still consider to be true” at a “level of complexity that can be challenging for those accustomed to thinking in dichotomous and dualistic ways about issues they had considered to be clear cut” (Adams 2016, 28). Working with DBCAAHS to develop a praxis-based course focused on Danville’s local history of urban renewal and school desegregation as a case study in structural racism is thus in line with best practices for educators interested in students not simply “learning about” such inequities but providing them a platform for “consciousness-raising” and durable motivations to ameliorate structural racism in the future (Adams 2016, 30–31).⁶

The first author has now taught the “Lived Histories” course three times during Centre’s three-week January term (called “CentreTerm”; the course was taught in January 2021, 2023, and 2025). The course was expressly designed for CentreTerm, as students sign up for only one course during this time. This gives the instructor flexibility with scheduling students for community engagement activities such as field trips and interviews. The first iteration of the course was taught entirely online due to the COVID-19 pandemic⁷ but has been taught in person since then.⁸ The course has changed in terms of format and content over the years, but from the beginning the pedagogical goal of the course was to have students use the Danville context of urban renewal and school integration as a case study to think inductively about structural racism in the United States. Because of the condensed nature of the course and the focus on oral history, the content of the course is interactive and mostly narrative-based. In all versions of the course, one of the first components is to bring members of DBCAAHS to the students to have them discuss the local history of urban renewal and school integration. Key here is Mr. Mike Denis, a local historian who has worked for more than a decade on Black family genealogies and 19th/20th-century history in Boyle County, including the history of urban renewal (Denis 2023). As a former middle school history teacher from Maine, Mr. Denis is able to tell this story from the point of view

of a historian and outsider. Conversely, DBCAAHS President Mr. Michael Hughes was brought to Danville as an infant and is thus able to tell the local story of the 1950s through the 1970s from the first-hand perspective of an African American person who grew up in Danville and experienced structural change. This juxtaposition of perspectives sets the stage for students to think about the role of narrative in bringing the consequences of structural racism to light.

From there, we go on to think about regional case studies of urban renewal and its consequences in Louisville (many Centre students are from the Louisville metro area, and about half are from Kentucky) and Columbus, Ohio (the economic historian Trevon Logan at Ohio State has some excellent resources on urban renewal and redlining in the Columbus metro area). We engage with an incredible interactive data set on urban renewal projects in the United States called *Renewing Inequality: Family Displacements through Urban Renewal, 1950–1966* (University of Richmond Digital Scholarship Lab, n.d.). In this activity, students choose a place in the United States where they have either lived or spent significant time, and they explore the history of family displacement due to urban renewal in that location with this website's interactive maps and charts. Students read, reflect on, and discuss the book *Root Shock: How Tearing up City Neighborhoods Hurts America, and What We Can Do About It* (Fullilove 2016). This book fuses the economic history of urban renewal to investigative journalism and oral history, making the case from interviews that urban renewal projects led not only to the dissolution of Black communities nationwide, but also to intergenerational trauma and the evaporation of intergenerational wealth. In the most recent version of the course, students also read, reflected on, and discussed excerpts from *The Warmth of Other Suns: The Epic Story of America's Great Migration* (Wilkerson 2010), which, in addition to providing historical context for the post-Reconstruction history of Black America, is also based on in-depth oral history interviews. Finally, students also took a day-long field trip to the Roots 101 African American Museum in Louisville, KY. This museum is an immersive, multimedia tour through the history of Black slavery, abolition, racism, and migration out of the American South⁹ with in-person narration from CEO and founder Mr. Lamont Collins.

These events and activities are intended to use a holistic anthropological frame to provide evidence for students to consider how structural racism becomes visible once it is understood from multiple points of view and lived experiences that have historically been silenced in “official” channels such as newspapers, as well as physically on the landscape. In terms of textual silencing, the course repeatedly comes back to the juxtaposition between the narrative of urban renewal recounted in Danville's local paper, the *Danville Advocate-Messenger*, during the 1960s, and the version of events and impacts recounted by local Black residents. In terms of silencing on the landscape, for example, students consistently express chagrin and shock when they learn that Danville's downtown park, known as “Constitution Square,” which is currently green space that holds a weekly farmer's market, is the exact location of the Doric Lodge, the Black Masonic Hall that was the iconic center of Danville's Black community on Second Street. The Doric Lodge had been subsidized by local Black Masons and was built only 30 years before it was torn down during the urban renewal of Second Street in 1974. Today, the site

of the Doric Lodge is called “Governor's Circle” and consists of a monument with bronze relief busts of every governor of the Commonwealth, all of whom have been white.

Methodologically and in terms of student engagement, the “Lived Histories” course trains students to conduct semi-structured life history interviews, which they do in small groups with older members of Danville's Black community. Students also leave the course understanding the complex “back end” work involved in professional archiving, including the idea of informed consent and the associated consent and release documents, the role of the Institutional Review Board in overseeing research, the public nature of oral history interviewing and the limitations this poses on the kind of information that narrators will provide, creating transcripts and public access to the interviews, and the complexities of interpreting data that is by its nature imperfect and subjective.

The partnership with DBCAAHS has now been integrated into a suite of the first author's courses, including a linguistic anthropology course and the senior seminar for anthropology majors. The goal was thereby to create a flexible, productive, long-term, open-ended, and reciprocal community-based partnership with DBCAAHS. As of the spring 2025 semester, Centre students have conducted 40 oral history interviews with 35 current or former local Black residents and two former Centre College professors (some residents have been interviewed multiple times, and some were interviewed in pairs). More than 300 Centre students have been involved in the project in some way, and many majors in Centre College's combined Program in Anthropology and Sociology have been involved in multiple aspects of the project over the course of their undergraduate careers. Groups of Centre students and members of DBCAAHS have presented findings from the project at several regional and national anthropology and history conferences since 2022. DBCAAHS has engaged four student interns since 2020, and the project has also supported four students for summer research assistantships over the summers of 2022, 2023, and 2024. The project maintains, through the Grace Doherty Library at Centre College, a permanent site providing public access to all of the digital materials we have generated, including all of the long-form oral histories, audio clips of the oral histories created for the listening stations in the public exhibition (see below), the final timeline from the urban renewal period using articles from the *Danville Advocate-Messenger*, and archival photos and narrations from the public exhibition. The Centre library also hosts the “official” archival materials on servers that it maintains and pays for in “digital deep freeze.”

1.5 | The “We Were Here”¹⁰ Exhibition

During the 2022–23 academic year, the first author partnered with DBCAAHS and Centre College's Norton Center for the Arts, a large regional performing arts center with an annual visitation reaching over 55,000 that bills itself as “Central Kentucky's epicenter of the performing arts” (Norton Center for the Arts, Centre College: At a Glance n.d.), to curate an exhibition highlighting both the DBCAAHS photo collection and the results of our longitudinal partnership. Each semester, the Norton Center mounts an art installation in its main foyer, which is a large space through which every Norton Center patron passes to enter its theaters.

In the fall of 2021, the first author and DBCAAHS leadership approached the Norton Center Director, Steven Hoffman, with the unusual idea of mounting an exhibition focused on local Black history and Danville's urban renewal period. The Norton Center had never mounted an installation like this before, as all of its previous exhibitions had focused on fine art.

The resulting exhibition in the Norton Center was titled “*We Were Here*”: The African American Experience in Boyle County” (WWH).¹¹ It consisted of large-format archival pictures, explanatory text, a large-format version of the virtual timeline of the urban renewal period created by Centre students, listening stations with excerpts from the Black oral history collection curated by Centre students, and displays of artifacts from the DBCAAHS collection. The first author also contributed essays for the Norton Center's fall and spring programs that contextualized urban renewal in Danville and its effects on the Black community, as well as student contributions and reactions to the project, and argued for the role anthropology can take on a local level to address structural racism.

A final notable effect of the Norton Center partnership with DBCAAHS was the opportunity it afforded to invite the African American community into a space from which many had previously felt excluded. The Norton Center hosted both an opening reception for WWH in Fall 2022 and a tenth anniversary celebration for DBCAAHS in Spring 2023 that foregrounded WWH. Members of the local Black community, including all of those who had provided oral history interviews up to that time, were invited to these events. The Norton Center also provided free tickets to DBCAAHS to distribute to community members for performances related to the WWH exhibition, including a spoken word theatrical performance on African American history by the Wisconsin poet laureate Dasha Kelly Hamilton titled *Makin' Cake* and an opera recital by Eric Owens and singers from the Curtis Opera Theatre.

2 | “*We Were Here*” Participants Reflect on Their Involvement

2.1 | Methods

During the summer of 2023, the first author and a student researcher (the fourth author) contacted 14 participants who had provided an oral history to the project between January 2021 and January 2023. These 14 initial contacts resulted in interviews with eight participants (six men and two women). This represented more than one-third (36%) of the oral history participants up to that point in time, yielding a diverse and representative sample of opinions on the WWH Project and the DBCAAHS-Centre College partnership. In order to maintain consistency between interviews, we structured all eight interviews around six core questions: (1) What were your motivations for participating in the “*We Were Here*” Project? (2) Why is oral history important? (3) Who benefits from the “*We Were Here*” Project? (4) How does the “*We Were Here*” Project affect the local white community? (5) How do you evaluate Centre College's involvement in the “*We Were Here*” Project? (6) Do you have any critiques of the “*We Were Here*” project?/What could have gone better in presenting the project or in the community partnership?

Interviews were conducted on Zoom for ease of recording and were transcribed using Otter.ai software, with the student researcher checking the transcriptions for accuracy. These transcriptions were then manually edited for concision and excerpted to include only responses relevant to the six core questions above. These excerpts were then analyzed using the qualitative data analysis platform LiGRE. In essence, this method employed large deductive categories (the six core questions listed above), and then coding proceeded inductively according to standard qualitative coding procedures (e.g., Emerson et al. 2011, 175). The first author performed all of the coding.

In what follows, we report the number of responses that correspond to a particular response theme as labeled in LiGRE. As respondents were free to give as many responses as they wished for each interview question, this number of responses is larger than the number of participants. We did not make any assumptions about the relative importance of each response; rather, we are interested here in the number of participants who provided responses corresponding to a particular theme. All data from oral history participants was gathered under the review and approval of the Centre College Institutional Review Board. Oral history participants were explicitly informed that because of the public nature of oral history projects, their narrations would not be anonymous and would be publicly available on the internet. However, though what we report below was collected under the same IRB protocol, we chose to maintain the anonymity of the participants in this venue.

2.2 | Results

“It's always been the [same] story: when I grew up, that Centre College didn't care about the community, didn't care about the African American community, and the only thing they cared about was getting the land. But as you started to get into the research and the history of it—and the students, the research that they've done, you know, everybody couldn't do that. And like for the timelines that [were] created for the ‘*We Were Here*’ Project, that's something that probably never would have been revealed. If it wasn't for the Centre College commitment, the classes' commitment to finding that history. So, you know, it's been special.” —Michael Hughes, DBCAAHS President, March 24, 2023

The quote above speaks positively to the possibilities of the project that we undertook in our partnership: that there could be a synergistic relationship between a higher ed PWI and the local Black community in which undergraduate students were capacitated to conduct, record, transcribe, and archive semi-structured oral history interviews. Even further, we wanted to be sure that there would be a tangible and positive outcome for members of the local community who have been affected by structural racism. Assuming our “success” in this endeavor, however, even according to our community partner above, did not seem sufficient. Indeed, a crucial aspect of PAR that is easily neglected is to collect iterative feedback from community partners. In going back to and hearing from these folks, we hoped

that we could create such an iterative discourse with our partners as the project went on and thereby make “course corrections” to better serve community members’ wishes as we continue to accrue and display local Black history.

We first asked respondents to talk about their motivations for participating in the WWH Project. The modal response to this question (7/19 responses) was that telling their story of Danville’s urban renewal period would “impact younger generations.” For some respondents, there were concrete outcomes related to this “impact.” One relevant theme here was truth and accuracy of historical events. One respondent framed this through the lens of correcting “edited” or “sanitized” history:

“I think we need to capture for the future or for posterity and for historical accuracy. That’s from individuals who have actually lived through the periods that we’re talking about. So it isn’t left to someone to guess what the reaction was or what people felt or what they went through. Nor will it be subject to sort of this historical correctness that has taken place right now. So that’s the reason for me is to have it recorded and have it be there to give people in the future an opportunity to listen, look, and get a real sense of what individuals who’ve lived through these times really felt, what they reacted to, and why they went through the things that they did, what the impact was.”

A second reason for wanting this project to impact younger people was to educate young Black community members on the legacy of structural inequalities that they continue to face. One respondent’s experience during urban renewal was that he had been removed from the house he had been renting for his young family in the Seventh Street area. Danville’s Urban Renewal Agency offered to build him a new house that he could pay off with a mortgage, but he reports that at the last minute, the agency told him he would have to take out a second mortgage, making the offer unaffordable. He was never re-housed in a home built with urban renewal funds. His interview response evokes themes of practical intergenerational knowledge of property rights and home ownership:

“After I thought about it, it came to me that it was a good idea to participate, so that people will know what actually happened in Danville during the urban renewal, and it impacted me and my family, you know, and other people of color, who were trying to get homes under the circumstances and how that they didn’t. The people there didn’t give us the right information, you know, they actually lied to us about certain things. And people need to know that now. And in the future, too. ... it gives them a good idea of what to look out for when it comes time to purchase a home, you know? And to get other legal advice before signing any contracts or anything. ... Especially dealing with real estate, banks and things, you know, they sometimes don’t give you the right information.”

The second most common response was that respondents wanted to make sure they left an “accurate representation of history” of Black Danville in the 1960s and 70s (6/19 responses). Other, though related, responses were that “young people today have a lack of knowledge of history” (2/19 responses), that urban renewal “negatively affected Danville’s Black community” (2/19 responses), that they wanted to speak because urban renewal “affected them and their own family” (1/19 responses), and that the legacy of urban renewal “affects the present” (1/19 responses).

Next, we asked respondents about the methodology we used in the project: oral history, and why a narrative approach is particularly useful for this kind of project. There were 10 response themes for this question. Two of these 10 themes spoke to a critical aspect of oral history research—that it provides a “corrective” for dominant narratives of local history by asking people who are not usually asked to narrate and disseminate their experience. For example, one respondent spoke to the fact that since the urban renewal period, the Black community in Danville had been so effectively erased that there were no other outlets to keep stories of that period alive:

“I haven’t talked to anyone in the community other than the Centre College representatives because we don’t have any talks about it [in the Black community]. We just don’t have the organizations and the clubs and different things that you need to bring up such topics, other than church. ... I try to emphasize the benefit of what we, the Historical Society and Centre College input, how it helped everything to be exposed. And some things that we just didn’t know, we didn’t know as a community. And I’m assuming that some things about the African American community, that the whites did not know. So, I think it’s been an enlightenment for both parties.”

Related themes spoke to the fact that oral history serves to “keep history alive” (2/10 responses), that it can “teach people in the current generation” (2/10 responses), that it provides a “corrective to misinformation” about the past (1/10 responses), that listening to oral histories can “affect people’s thinking and affect the future” (1/10 responses), that it “provides models for Black success” (in showing how local Black people owned businesses and formed community; 1/10 responses), and that recording and disseminating oral history “creates equity” (1/10 responses).

In all, in asking oral history narrators to provide their motivation to participate and their thoughts on oral history as a method, respondents provided clear and concrete reasons that they saw both benefit and utility to the methods and outcomes of our partnership.

Next, we were interested in how oral history participants thought about the distribution of benefits arising from the outcomes of the project. We asked this question in an open-ended manner (i.e., “Who benefits from this project?”). In essence, respondents were free to conclude that because of the historical tensions between the Black community and Centre College, Centre students, fac-

ulty, and/or administration would end up benefiting more than community members, or that they had been “taken advantage of” in some way (since the oral histories are housed on Centre’s servers, the *‘We Were Here’* Project was mounted at a Centre College facility, or the like).

No respondent made this conclusion. Of the 14 response themes for this question, the heavily modal response was that “young Black and white community members” or “the whole community” benefits from the project outcomes (8/14 responses). Other themes included “young Black community members” (3/14 responses), “the oral history participants” (1/14 responses), “older African American community members” (1/14 responses), and “DBCAAHS” (1/14 responses). A typical explanation of this response was that the narrative disseminated by the project is beneficial and healing for the community:

“The information in the project, I think it spreads awareness across the whole community. ... from Centre College to the schools, that they get this information [now] in their high schools, middle schools, or whatever. I think it kind of helps to pull the community together a little bit, that other areas of the community know this history, or know about this project.”

We then asked two follow-up questions to further probe for critiques of the partnership and/or the project outcomes. First, we asked specifically about benefits to the local white community from the project outcomes. No respondent reported that the white community benefited to the detriment of the Black community. Rather, the modal response suggested that the oral history project had a pedagogical value: that it would allow members of the white community to “understand the experience and consequences of racism” (5/9 responses). Relatedly, 2 of 9 responses claimed that the project outcomes would “teach white community members what they did not know.” Finally, two responses demurred from the direct line of questioning, claiming that the project “benefits all community members.” In understanding oral history as pedagogical, several respondents claimed that it provided an equity-minded corrective to white narratives of history:

“I think [the white community] would [benefit]. But I think, in a way, the African American community is a lot different than other groups. Because we have been left out. And we’ve been taken advantage of, and I don’t see for a long time, if we’ll ever get anything back.... The reason I’ve benefited is [that] I feel like I’ve got people that do hear what our plight is. I might not be always correct in how I present it. But I do feel now that we’re being heard, at least.”

The second follow-up question asked specifically about the way that Centre College has benefited from this project. To put as fine a point on the question as possible, the first author also gave some examples to the respondents, including the fact that the oral histories are stored on Centre’s servers, that Centre students were gaining skills and academic credit for participating, and that Centre funded the project. No respondent agreed that Centre’s benefits were to the detriment of the project outcomes or the

Black community. The modal response (5/21 responses) indicated, to the contrary, that they found the project and its outcomes “inspiring,” insofar as it shows elements of the community that have not historically been on good terms “working together”:

“I love [the partnership], yes, it’s really good. It’s awesome, that they are doing that. ... it seems to me that [Centre College and the Black community] are both working together. And I think that it’s needed. And I think that’s a blessing to Danville, that you have Centre College and the African American Historical Society, you know, everybody’s working together to show history. That’s truly a blessing.”

Another reason respondents gave for the fact that they thought Centre housing the project outcomes was positive is the community perception that Centre, as an institution, is “stable,” while direct community curation of such material is perceived as more fickle (4/21 responses). For one respondent, this fact is unfortunately linked to the historical erasure of Black wealth, community, and property:

“Well, I’m most thankful that Centre College is housing it, because Centre will be here as long as Danville’s here. And it’s a reputable college and they can take care of it, where we don’t have no place to put it. We as a race of people, we can’t do that. So, I’m thankful that Centre is doing it. So I have no problem with it. ... just take [the example of] the African American Historical Society: until we get more organized and have a place of our own, I just don’t see what can be done. ... We need a place bigger than what we’ve got. We don’t have, other than the church, a place that belongs to African Americans to display it.”

A final response (3/21 responses) was interesting in that it reflected the ongoing, iterative, and productive aims of the project, namely that Centre involving itself in the project “provides a model to other higher ed PWIs.” This was an encouraging response because it demonstrated to the authors that community participants were thinking about this project beyond the scale of Danville and Boyle County. As one respondent put it:

“You know, maybe other colleges and universities need to know that that information is housed at Centre College. It needs to be spread out so that it can be shared with other people.”

Another respondent framed this “model” in terms of “benchmarking” for inclusive history projects:

“I think [housing the project at Centre] is very positive. And I think it can be a benchmark to other institutions and other communities to do the same thing.”

Other responses about the positive nature of housing the project at Centre included that the project “taught students, faculty, and administrators about urban renewal” (2/21 responses), that

Centre's involvement "indexes inclusivity" (2/21 responses), that Centre is "finally doing something to document Black history" (1/21 responses), that Centre's involvement "changes the African American perception of Centre positively" (1/21 responses), that Centre's financial resources and person power "made the project possible" (1/21 responses), that Centre's involvement "allows for wide dissemination" of the history (1/21 responses), and that without Centre's institutional interest, "no one would be motivated to pay attention" (1/21 responses).

Taken in full, the profile of the responses above points to an overwhelmingly positive assessment of the Centre-DBCAAHS partnership and the specific project outcomes. However, it is also clear that this positivity is couched in terms of a clear-eyed and pragmatic view of how Centre's involvement is a means to an end for the project participants: the partnership is beneficial because Centre College represents intergenerational stability, reputability in terms of its pedagogical and institutional goals, and the financial resources and person power to execute and house such a large-scale project. For the respondents, all of these elements are clearly the outcome of historical structural privileges afforded to Centre that were not afforded to the Black community, and in fact were taken away from the local Black community partly due to the very urban renewal projects that we were seeking to document in the project.

3 | Encouraging Inductive Student Takeaways From "We Were Here"

3.1 | Methods

One pedagogical question the Centre College-DBCAAHS oral history project asks is how successful the project artifacts are in catalyzing what Wright (2015) calls "sociopolitical analysis development," in which students become able to connect "personal, micro-level experiences of sociopolitical inequities into larger, macro-level sociopolitical forces" (2015, 170). During the time that the WWH exhibition was mounted in the Norton Center (August 2022 to June 2023), the first author: 1. gave two formal talks with a largely undergraduate audience focused on WWH artifacts and their analysis, and 2. taught a January Term course that focused on the WWH exhibition materials, the DBCAAHS partnership, and then on conducting and archiving oral history interviews on urban renewal and school desegregation in Danville.

In each of these settings, after interacting with WWH materials, the first author asked students explicitly to reflect, in writing, on the significance of understanding urban renewal at various sociopolitical scales. The question prompts employed were slightly altered versions of the Harvard Graduate School of Education's "Project Zero's Thinking Routines Toolbox" (Harvard Graduate School of Education n.d.). The routine employed was "The Three Whys," which is intended to make respondents reflect on local-global connections. After hearing the talk by the first author or members of DBCAAHS and interacting with the WWH materials, the students were asked to reflect on one or more of the following questions: Why does historical placemaking in Black Danville communities and the story of urban renewal matter to (1) Me? (2) Centre College and others around me? (3) The United

States and/or The World? Students were free to answer one, more than one, or all of these questions and were given several minutes to think about and write a response using the interactive presentation application *Pear Deck*. Of the 45 students who are represented in this sample, 21 came from audience members at the two formal talks given by the first author in the fall of 2022. The other 24 came from the "Lived Histories" course in 2023.¹² The responses included in the sample are only from those students who gave explicit permission for their writing to be used in this research project under the first author's IRB protocol.

The written student responses were analyzed in a similar manner to the WWH participants' interviews above. The questions students were asked to respond to formed deductive categories that the first author then coded inductively for content themes. Because the students had the freedom to answer one or more than one of the three questions listed above, there were a total of 76 responses analyzed among the 45 students. Below, we report on all of the response themes with more than two exemplars to give a sense of the modal responses to the reflective questions. To be clear, the data we present below reflect student thinking after interacting with the "We Were Here" Project materials (pictures, oral history audio clips, DBCAAHS artifacts, talks by DBCAAHS members, and talks by the first author); these were not post-course reflections but rather synchronic reflections on their ongoing engagement.

3.2 | Results

We begin with the modal responses to the question, "Why does historical placemaking in Black Danville communities and the story of urban renewal matter to The United States and/or The World?" The most common theme associated with this question was "Danville is a microcosm of larger structural phenomena" (12 responses). One student framed this idea in terms of the relative "intelligibility" of urban renewal in Danville's small-town context relative to large cities:

"[The project] offers a distinct level of insight toward how urban renewal could have impacted other urban communities around the country. Due to the small size of Danville, it was certainly possible to piece together a full history of the Black community, as we see with the 'We Were Here' exhibition, which is not something that would be nearly as easily done in a much larger city. Therefore, we are able to see a detailed account of events that impacted the community, culture, and social structure of the Black residents of Danville, and we can examine it deeply because it is not incredibly large. This becomes important because we are likely to see the same trends and impacts in larger cities across the nation where documenting in detail would be vastly more challenging, simply due to the sheer size and number of people. We are able to see, feel, and learn the history, and through this we are able to hear the cry of the people."

The second most common theme was that urban renewal “reflects a power imbalance/hierarchy in US history and class structure” (5 responses). One student put this sentiment in terms of the burden of historical erasure:

“The history of the Black Danville Communities and urban renewal tie into each other in a bittersweet way.... The dangers of one-sided narratives more often than not dictate the future interaction of [different kinds of] others and their descendants. The pain and sorrow of losing a home, losing a place, and the extinction of identity can [thus] be manipulated and [re]branded into [something] that never existed. Being forgotten in a place you once called home, [and] the removal of a part of yourself, is a large burden to carry.”

The final theme was that WWH “gives voice to and acknowledges a minoritized community” (2 responses). One student, who has interacted with WWH material and conducted oral history interviews on multiple occasions, put this idea succinctly:

“Each [oral history] represent[s] a critical part of historical Black communities in Danville, however we rarely examine them on a micro scale. I find this to be a useful exercise not only for students at Centre who want to learn more about Black communities, but for those that actually lived these experiences. The mere mention of the Ponderosa [a defunct night club on south Second Street] evokes pleasant memories for most who inhabited this space, and oftentimes they’re eager to tell about their experiences. In re-discovering the lost institutions of Danville, students can open opportunities for Black voices to be heard.”

There were three response themes with more than two exemplars to the question “Why does historical placemaking in Black Danville communities and the story of urban renewal matter to Centre College and others around me?” The first response theme was that the project “gives voice to those affected over the narratives of hegemonic institutions” (8 responses):

“It is important to hear from citizens who went through a time of change like this because all too often the stories and the narratives that we hear are formulated by the people doing the changing, the big corporations, in Danville: Centre College and the Urban Renewal committee. They are not going to speak badly about what they had done, so to find the truth we must delve deeper and ask hard questions to those who went through that time.”

The second response theme focused on the idea that the oral histories “provide an ‘accurate’ representation of history” (8 responses). One student framed this idea of “missing narratives” in terms of being “heard”:

“The history of Black Danville Communities and urban renewal might be very important to people around me because there is still a large amount of history unrecorded. Black communities still in Danville and those that had to relocate due to urban renewal need justice for the wrongdoings that caused them to relocate, lose their homes and land, [and] lose their sense of community. It is important that the history be talked about, shared intentionally, and discovered because the people who experienced it deserve to be heard, and it is now our duty to document the histories because we are the generation living after.”

The next response theme was that WWH “helps to understand how Centre was involved in/motivated by urban renewal and Black displacement” (5 responses):

“Historical placemaking in Danville’s African American community should matter to Centre College because Centre has played a big role in urban renewal in Danville and has directly contributed to the displacement of African Americans in Danville. In doing this work to remember the meaningful places to the African American community, Centre is recognizing and giving back at least some of what they helped to take away.”

The final theme in this question was that the project “connects ‘disconnected’ Centre students to the local community” (5 responses). This theme centers on the idea that Centre students are mostly newcomers to Danville and highlights students’ perception that they never really become a “part of” the Danville community while they are here because of the heavy time demands of being a college student. This idea is colloquially known by students, faculty, and staff as the “Centre bubble”:

“Students constantly speak about the ‘Centre Bubble,’ and how that impacts them in terms of where they go, what they are able to access while on campus, and how connected they are to campus social life. What rarely gets discussed is how a ‘Centre Bubble’ relates to the placemaking happening down the street from where we live. What is Centre’s impact on the Danville community? How do Danville residents view Centre’s presence? Our own experiences of Danville as students are definitely enriched by learning about other feelings of place here. But more importantly, we can only honestly and openly reckon with Centre’s historical legacy and impact in Danville by searching for voices who can share their own stories first.”

There was one response theme with more than two exemplars to the question “Why does historical placemaking in Black Danville communities and the story of urban renewal matter to me?” This was that understanding urban renewal “provides context for what Danville looks like today” (4 responses). One student framed their realization of the historical erasure of landscape in very personal terms:

"The '*We Were Here*' exhibit was really powerful to me, to see all that the strong Black community of Danville had lost. The one that really stood out to me is the destruction of Seventh Street for urban renewal. I now live in the location in those dorms where a strong Black community lived and thrived and was destroyed. This matters to me because it makes me think about my hometown of Ashland, Kentucky. Ashland is very similar to Danville in its past segregation and size. This similarity and the fact that this urban renewal occurred all across the entire United States really makes me wonder how the Black community in my hometown was affected and what they lost."

Taken in full, student interaction with WWH exhibition materials and members of DBCAAHS resulted in rich, varied, and robust reflections on the nature of racialized discourses in United States history and the sticky and persistent nature of the structural barriers that these discourses, and their historical erasure in narrative, text, and the landscape, engender both in Danville and in the United States.

4 | Black Oral History: Outcomes and the Future

Aspirational principles for positive change on issues of social justice, such as correcting the public record and raising public awareness of persistent structural racism, can be successfully addressed for both community partners and undergraduate students within the bureaucratic constraints of the university setting using PAR-informed cultural anthropological methods. The "*We Were Here*" Project accomplished this marriage of disciplinary and institutional imperatives.

The goal of the current project was to build a longitudinal, community-engaged partnership using methods drawing heavily from cultural anthropology that could synthesize the positive aspects of community-engaged learning for community partners and for students with applied anthropological work. We reported on a long-term collaboration that focused on capacitating anthropology students at a PWI SLAC to execute, publicly archive, and meaningfully reflect on and compare semi-structured oral history interviews with members of the local African American community who had experienced local urban renewal projects and mandated school integration in the 1960s and 1970s. Over the course of several years, this project led to a large-scale public history and art exhibition. In this way, its motivations were different from traditional community-engaged learning, which tends to be standing opportunities for student community engagement led by a campus unit such as an office for engaged learning (Rodríguez-Mejía 2021, 19). However, by using principles of PAR and framing the project around capacitating students to carry out ethnographic semi-structured interview methods, we were able to successfully synthesize real applied anthropological work with meaningful community-engaged learning for hundreds of undergraduates. The project thus bridged some of the gap between generalized "community-engaged" opportunities as historically curated in the university setting and the peculiarities

of anthropology as a discipline that relies on particular methods to understand cultural difference.

Much of the above documentation and analysis has been about capacitating the local community to provide, and students to collect, a corrective narrative of the past. However, to conclude, we would like to highlight one initially unintended aspect of the "*We Were Here*" Project: the perception that it will affect the future. In an essay for the Norton Center for the Arts' fall 2022 program, the first author summarized the outcome of the "*We Were Here*" project as fundamentally about appreciating the past:

While ["*We Were Here*"] is certainly a story about race and structural power, it is also, perhaps more importantly, about providing a platform where story, memory, and joy are able to merge, to evoke an alternative, though admittedly long-gone, "sense of place" and to allow it to hang in the air for just a moment, for all of our consideration. Personally, I can think of no finer use for anthropology than that.

More than 2 years later, the first author would like to stand partially corrected on this front. Indeed, judging from the debrief interviews with WWH participants and with students interacting with and producing WWH material, this project has *always* been about informing and enabling both Black futures and Centre student futures. For local African Americans who had never been asked and had no venue to tell their story of urban renewal publicly, almost all reported that they see clearly that young people, both Black and otherwise, would make productive use of the knowledge that came from their narratives, either because structural racism continues today or because young people would now have the knowledge to advocate for its dissolution. For the students' part, they saw clearly the impact that these narratives would have both on their self-reflexive understanding of place and their social agency in response to understanding the history of structural racism in the places they occupy. Further, students were also capacitated with ethnographic methods that they could use to effect similar outcomes in the future. As DBCAAHS president Michael Hughes put it, "I think in the long run, for the students, after they graduate, I really think a lot of them will continue to want to be part of this type of research." In this spirit, we can think of no finer use for anthropology than capacitating the future.

Endnotes

¹The oral history narrators we first approached were in their 70s, 80s, and 90s, and we began collecting oral histories remotely in January 2021. Devastatingly, we were only able to begin interviews after several people DBCAAHS members wished to record had passed away from COVID-19.

²In line with what epidemiologists Dean and Thorpe (2022) point to as the "most contemporary and updated definition" of structural racism (1523), we refer to "structural racism" as "the totality of ways in which societies foster racial discrimination through mutually reinforcing systems of housing, education, employment, earnings, benefits, credit, media, health care, and criminal justice" (Bailey et al. 2017, 1454).

³ A fuller discussion of Danville's urban renewal period can be found on our digital archive of the "We Were Here" Project at: <https://wewerehere.omeka.net/exhibits/show/wewerehere>

⁴ A fuller discussion of student involvement with DBCAAHS and local Black history in particular courses can be found on our digital archive of the "We Were Here" Project at: <https://wewerehere.omeka.net/exhibits/show/wewerehere>

⁵ This timeline can be seen in our digital archive of the "We Were Here" Project at: <https://wewerehere.omeka.net/exhibits/show/wewerehere>

⁶ As an example of how this pedagogical intention is built into the "Lived Histories" course, here is an excerpt from the "course description" section of the course syllabus: "The goal of an anthropological approach to history, as a recent prominent publication put it, is to elicit and study 'the ways in which people variously conceptualize and morally evaluate the past in its relation to the present (and future)' (Palmié and Stewart 2016). Following this goal, in this course we will focus on understanding how other people interpret their own lived experience in their contexts: within relationships to their own families and friends, but also in relationship to powerful social structures beyond their direct control. This is a course about unearthing personal relationships to history that often go untold and underappreciated if we only think of history as 'events' and 'politics' and the lives of those we are told are 'prominent.'" The corresponding learning outcome reads: "You will understand an anthropological approach to history as contingent, shared, lived experience. You will do this by reflecting on the relationship of power and structure to particular communities, through discussions of course readings, and by transcribing, coding, and interpreting the interview(s) you carry out."

⁷ All CentreTerm courses were taught virtually in 2021.

⁸ One fortuitous consequence of the course being taught online in 2021 was that it forced the first author to find a technical workaround for recording interviews on Zoom or phone that were as high quality as possible. The first author was able to get access to funds through Centre College's Center for Teaching and Learning to purchase podcasting equipment that included inputs for laptop/phone. This technology has allowed our team to branch out widely in the ensuing years and to interview people who are either too infirm to be interviewed in person, or who no longer live in the Danville area.

⁹ <https://www.roots-101.org/>

¹⁰ The title "We Were Here" is in quotation marks because it was taken from the last line of an original play written by the artistic director of Danville's Pioneer Playhouse, Robbie Henson. The play was first produced in 2016 and commemorates Danville's vanished Black entrepreneurial district on South Second Street (Norton Center for the Arts, Centre College "We Were Here: Origins of the Name." n.d.).

¹¹ <https://nortoncenter.com/we-were-here/>

¹² The first author has taught the "Lived Histories" course three times, in January 2021, 2023, and 2025. The current study only encompassed the 2022-2023 academic year, during the period that WWH was displayed in the Norton Center for the Arts. In the 2023 iteration of the "Lived Histories" course, 25 of 27 (93%) students consented to have their written responses reproduced for research purposes. A total of 69 students have participated in the three iterations of "Lived Histories," so these 24 students represent 35% of the students who have enrolled in the course overall.

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